

General Macroeconomic Report

Confidential planning brief | Generated for Strategy Task Force review

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Source: Global Media Strategy Group

Data window: Jan 2024-Mar 2026

Regions: UK, US, EU5

Executive Summary

The global entertainment market is navigating a period of selective consumer spending rather than outright demand decline. Disposable income remains pressured by food, rent, transport, and energy costs, and players are becoming more deliberate about premium purchases. Consumers are buying fewer full-price games overall, but they are spending more hours inside the titles that earn trust quickly and continue to offer social, creative, or mastery-based reasons to return.

This is creating a split market. Premium titles with short campaign loops and limited community extension face higher launch-week pressure. By contrast, genres with durable player expression, moddable systems, creator content, competitive mastery, or cooperative identity loops are better positioned to convert one purchase into months of engagement. The macro environment therefore favors games that can justify price through repeatable use rather than spectacle alone.

7.8%

average decline in full-price launch purchases among price-sensitive console households

+21%

growth in average hours spent in players' top two games year over year

64%

surveyed players waiting for reviews before buying unfamiliar premium games

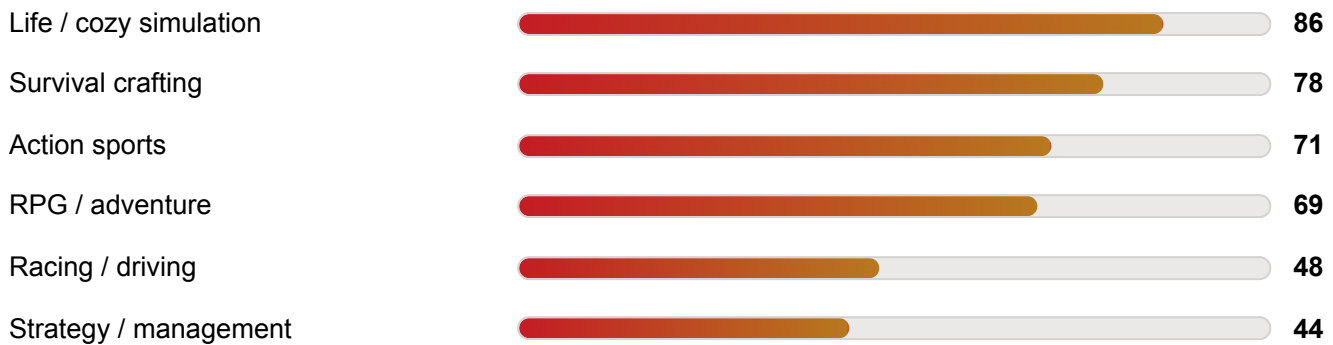
3.4x

retention advantage for games with robust user-generated content ecosystems

Key Macro Forces

- Cost-of-living pressure:** Players are consolidating leisure spend into fewer trusted games. This benefits titles that can become social or creative routines, and it weakens projects that depend on a single campaign completion cycle.
- Subscription service plateau:** Subscription growth is flattening across major platforms. Day-one inclusion can still drive reach, but it is less effective as a substitute for product-market fit, community trust, and post-launch engagement.
- Hardware lifecycle maturity:** Current console hardware is now mature. Developers can win through optimization, polish, input feel, and content cadence rather than large graphics pipeline reinvention.
- Creator-led discovery:** Short-form video and community creators are becoming a mainstream discovery path. Genres that generate visible, player-authored moments receive more repeatable unpaid promotion.

Genre Exposure



Audience Quotes

"I buy fewer new games now, but if one becomes my main hangout I will keep spending time in it."

UK player, 24, console and PC

"I need to know a premium game has depth before paying full price. Reviews and creator clips matter."

US player, 31, PC

"Cosmetics are fine if the base game is generous and the tools are good. I do not want another empty store page."

EU player, 19, console

"A good community can make a game feel cheaper because I keep coming back to see what people made."

UK player, 27, PC

Strategic Recommendation

Studios should avoid judging opportunities by total addressable market alone. The more useful macro question is whether a genre can create trusted long-term participation under household spending pressure. Concepts with player-authored content, strong identity expression, repeatable mastery, or mod-friendly ecosystems are structurally advantaged, provided the production plan is disciplined enough to deliver those loops reliably.